

EDCI 573 Practicum Fact Sheet

1. What is the purpose of the EDCI 57300 practicum?

The practicum experience is designed to allow students to engage in the practice of instructional or learning systems design in classroom and workplace settings. While participating in the practicum you will combine effective design with project management, planning and implementation. To this point in your program you have had several in-class learning opportunities, the practicum is an opportunity to apply your acquired instructional design skills and practice those in a more real world setting. Basically, the practicum is an instructional design, development, and/or evaluation project you carry out for a client.

2. What types of projects will be acceptable for the practicum?

Practicum projects will vary greatly based upon the customer/audience for whom they are being completed. The project should be focused on giving you experience designing and developing instructional materials or some type of performance/learning system. In some cases, the focus will be within the analysis/design phase where a majority of the work is gathering data via learning and task analyses, in other cases the project may be mostly about the development of the actual materials to be presented, while others may emphasize evaluation. In many cases, it will involve completing the full task from initial analyses through the final summative evaluations.

Examples of past projects have included: a) work flow and trainee analyses and training development for tellers at the local credit union; b) conversion of face-to-face training at a major chemical company into individualized e-Learning modules at a pharmaceutical company; c) development of a unit on North American Indians for a fifth grade elementary class; d) developing and presenting a training opportunity at the local library as a volunteer; e) formative evaluation of staff training within a veterans hospital; and f) development of performance support tools for the use of newly designed equipment at a manufacturing facility.

3. How BIG is this practicum project?

Each project will vary; however, for general planning purposes, you should plan on spending approximately 10-12 hours of work on this project per week. That will give you roughly 80-100 hours of work that will be devoted to the completion of this work. Projects that will require less than approximately 8 hours of work per week can still be used; however, a second project should be instigated in order to fulfill the full practicum requirement.

4. Who determines which project I will complete for my practicum experience?

You do. You will go out into your own community, school, place of employment and find your potential projects. Believe it or not, once you have completed EDCI 572 and other LDT courses, you actually have the knowledge and skills (although at times these are not yet fully polished) that will be of value to others. Locate an opportunity within your place of employment or community that needs the work of an instructional designer and offer your services. Look for ID jobs that need to be completed or ones that you always wish you had the time and effort to complete. Talk with those who would be involved in granting you permission and see what the possibilities will be. It is generally suggested that you find more than one possibility for your practicum project, in that way, if something doesn't work out, you have a back-up project.

5. What are the basic steps involved in getting a project approved?

a) Identify a potential project and talk with those in authority at that location to see if such a project is possible to be completed during the time period of the practicum. You must get buy-in from the

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organization where the project will occur – a critical part of the practicum is your ability to work within that organization's environment and with a supervisor from that organization;

- b) Write a short (1 page) pre-proposal that describes basically what the project would entail, where it would occur, who would be your assigned project supervisor (name and contact information), and what your role in the project would be. Communicate this pre-proposal with your EDCI 573 course instructor (NOTE: if you are completing this pre-proposal *prior* to the start of the EDCI 573 course, you may not know who your course instructor is. In such a case, send your pre-proposal to your faculty committee chair person and that individual can review your idea and give you permission to go to the next stage in the proposal process).
- c) Once the pre-proposal has been approved, complete the full proposal and timeline that will be outlined within the course. This proposal and timeline will need to be reviewed and agreed upon by your supervisor where the work will be completed (e.g., a school principal, a supervisor at work, the training director at the factory) and signed by that individual.
- d) The signed proposal is then submitted to the practicum course instructor and feedback is given and final acceptance is based on that feedback.

6. What is the project proposal?

Within the course, the first task will be to complete a project proposal that will describe what the project is, how it will be completed, the proposed timeline, all major artifacts that will be produced, as well as information about the organization and the supervisor who will be the contact person within that organization.

7. What will be the major EDCI 57300 practicum course requirements?

The exact manner in which the course will operate will be determined by the individual faculty members who will be the course instructors; however, generally the course will require the following:

- a. pre-proposal application (to make sure you have selected a project that is worth pursuing)
- b. formal proposal with timeline that include the following: the title of the project, description of the practicum site and assigned supervisor, description of the proposed project and project artifacts to be developed, summary of Ed Tech skills to be applied to the project, and role of the student
- c. status reports (in Brightspace) that describe your project progression, experiences, timeline adjustments, and so forth.
- d. project artifacts (items created by the student during the course of the practicum). These will vary based on the type of project and may include learner analyses, learning objectives, progress reports, designed, developed, and distributed instructional and/or performance materials/products)
- e. final project with narrative

8. Who should serve as my on-site project supervisor?

This will depend upon the organization where the practicum is going to be completed. This needs to be an individual who will be in a position to know the value of the project from the organization's perspective. Each practicum project must have an on-site supervisor. So, if you are working on a project within your school organization, the supervisor should be a school administrator or a department

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chairperson. In a business environment, it would be someone that would have input into the targeted training or performance support tool. The supervisor will be the contact person who the course instructor will depend upon to give insights and feedback into how the project is progressing and how the project will be accepted once it is completed.

9. When can I start my project?

Practicum projects often don't line up perfectly with the term when the EDCI 57300 course is being taken. If you find the "perfect" practicum but it starts earlier than the course, it is possible for you to complete a pre-proposal (from the EDCI 57300 course instructor if you know who that will be; however, if that is not possible, contact your faculty chairperson and that person can help guide you in this regard), and gain approval to begin the project.

Important note: The practicum is considered one of the culminating experiences of the program. Thus it is designed to be undertaken after a large number of the courses in the program have been completed. Potential practicum projects will not be approved prior to a student successfully completing the following courses: EDCI 569, 572, and 672. In addition, approval of practicum project prior to the onset of the practicum course does not guarantee the practicum instructor will approve the project or what has been completed prior to the onset of the formal course. The grading for the practicum project will be completed by the regular course instructor.

10. When should the project be completed?

This project needs to be designed to be completed within the 7-week structure of the course. However, projects in the real world often start and stop at times outside of the normal course term. Communicate with the EDCI 573 course instructor prior to the start of the course if you have an opportunity to work on the project before the official start of the class. If you don't know who the course instructor will be, contact the chair of your committee and that faculty member can help guide you in this process. If the project is going to be completed after the final days of the scheduled class, you will need to discuss this with your course instructor so the requirements for the course can be completed successfully within the time frame of the course.

11. Who will grade the project?

All grading will be completed by the EDCI 57300 course instructor. That said, the instructor will receive and consider feedback from the organization's project supervisor about the quality, completeness, and timeliness of the project.

12. What if I "just can't find a project"?

Actually, this is an important part of the overall project. Searching and identifying a proper place for your practicum adds value to your overall learning experience. It helps you to determine how to explain what you have learned and why it would be important for an organization to use your skills. The beauty of the world of instructional design and development is that everyone needs to learn and so our services are needed (many people just need to be educated on what we can do – once they know, they find all kinds of projects that need to be done). If you are currently finding it difficult to figure out something to do at your current area of employment, one suggestion is to volunteer your efforts at a not-for-profit organization, your church, the city library, the local hospital. One individual found great success by developing safety instructional materials for an organization similar to Habitat for Humanity.

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13. When and how will the course instructor and my practicum supervisor communicate about the project?

This is generally completed via email. Generally, there will be an introductory communication and then periodic communications (check ins about the progress) that will include a midterm communication and a final communication at the end of the term.